

Global Peace Israel Report:

The Curriculum of Erasure

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How New York City Schools Included Jews by Redefining Them

A new public school curriculum promises to bring Jewish history out of the margins. Read closely, it does something else: it acknowledges Jews while quietly editing out the parts of Jewish identity which explain why Jews exist as a People at all.

New York City Public Schools created *Hidden Voices* with a worthy promise: to bring overlooked histories into the classroom and help students see the people too often left out of the story of America.

That promise matters.

In a city as diverse as New York, students should learn the histories of the communities which shaped the Nation, the city, and the world around them. They should learn about people whose stories were minimized, distorted, or ignored. They should learn how prejudice works, how identity survives, and how democratic societies expand dignity over time.

But inclusion is not only about adding names to a curriculum. It is about telling the truth.

And *Hidden Voices: Jewish Americans in United States History* exposes a deeper problem in modern education: a school system can appear to include a People while quietly editing out the very things which define them.

The result is not outright exclusion. It is something subtler, which makes it more dangerous. It is inclusion by reduction.

The form of acknowledgment a People receives when a system needs to be seen welcoming them, and needs them smaller in order to do it.

Jewish Americans are acknowledged. Jewish individuals are celebrated. Jewish contributions are recognized. Students encounter stories of immigration, philanthropy, art, humor, civic life, and public service.

But the curriculum largely avoids the civilizational spine of Jewish identity: Peoplehood, ancestral Homeland, exile, return, sovereignty, Zionism, and the connection between Jewish self-determination and modern antisemitism.

That omission changes everything.

A Jewish curriculum which strips Jewish identity of Peoplehood does not fully teach Jewish history. It does not teach American history accurately either. And it certainly does not teach Jewish American history — which is what this volume claims to be — because Jewish American history is, by definition, the meeting point of an ancient People and a young Nation. Strip the Peoplehood from one side of that meeting, and what is left is no longer the history the title promises. It is a flattened account of a community whose American story cannot be

understood without the longer story which brought them here. It teaches a skewed view of America combined with a safer, narrower version of Jewishness — one which fits neatly inside a diversity framework but cannot explain why Jews have survived, why they have been hated, or why Jewish national identity remains central to Jewish life.

That is not true inclusion.

It is the illusion of inclusion.

Representation Is Not the Same as Truth

On the surface, *Hidden Voices* looks like progress. The series offers biographies, lesson prompts, classroom resources, vocabulary, and stories of underrepresented Americans. Its goal is to help students see people and communities too often left out of traditional curricula.

That is a good goal.

But good intentions do not guarantee good history.

In many identity-based curricula, communities are presented through collective struggle: land, dignity, rights, resistance, liberation, discrimination, pride, policy, and civic action.

In the Jewish volume, something different happens.

Jewish identity is filtered largely through individual achievement. Students meet admirable people. They encounter artists, activists, philanthropists, writers, public figures, and cultural contributors.

But what they do not receive clearly enough is the coherent historical arc which explains Jewish identity as more than religion, more than culture, and more than immigrant success.

That missing arc is essential:

peoplehood → land → exile → survival → return → self-determination

Without that arc, Jewish identity becomes a collection of personal stories rather than the history of an ancient people.

That matters because Jews are not merely a faith group. Jews are a People, a civilization, a nation, an ethnic and religious community, and a historically persecuted minority whose identity has always included a relationship to land, language, memory, law, exile, and return.

When a curriculum removes that structure, students are left with fragments.

They may learn that Jews contributed to America.

They may learn that Jews experienced prejudice.

They may learn that Jews made art, supported civil rights, built institutions, and enriched public life.

But they are not given the deeper truth: Jews survived as a People long before America existed, and the modern Jewish return to sovereignty did not emerge from nowhere. It emerged from centuries of exile, persecution, longing, legal history, political organizing, and the persistent refusal of Jews to disappear.

A curriculum which cannot explain that cannot explain antisemitism.

Which begs the question: can it explain history at all? Does it understand what history is for?

One Word Can Change the Story

Consider how this works in practice.

The Jewish volume describes early Zionist aspirations using the phrase “a land of their own in Palestine.”

Without careful explanation, that phrase can mislead modern students.

In early twentieth-century documents, “Palestine” referred to the British Mandate for Palestine — a legal and geographic designation used before the establishment of the modern State of Israel. It was not a sovereign Palestinian state. It was a mandate territory connected to the Balfour Declaration and the League of Nations Mandate, both of which included language about a Jewish national home.

Without that context, students may hear the phrase through today’s political assumptions. They may interpret Jewish national revival as foreign intrusion into someone else’s established country, rather than as a complex historical movement tied to Jewish indigeneity, Ottoman collapse, British rule, international law, Arab opposition, and competing national claims.

That is not a minor wording issue.

It is a framing issue.

A more historically careful sentence would say:

Zionism sought a Jewish National Home in the Land of Israel, then part of the British Mandate for Palestine.

That wording does not erase Palestinians. It does not settle every political dispute. It does not turn the classroom into a political rally.

It simply gives students the context needed to think clearly.

This is one sentence in one curriculum. But it illustrates something larger: curriculum bias does not always announce itself loudly. It often appears in a single word, an omitted phrase, a missing name, or a sentence which seems neutral until students absorb its implication.

Good curriculum does not hide complexity. It equips students to understand it.

The Zionism Problem

The pattern visible in that single phrase shapes the volume’s treatment of Zionism as a whole.

The Jewish volume acknowledges Zionism as connected to Jewish national self-determination in the ancestral homeland. But the framing quickly shifts toward caution, disagreement, and a “range of views” about Zionism and Israel.

Of course Jewish Americans hold a range of views about Israeli politics, policies, borders, religion, government, and current events. That is true of every living people. Diversity of opinion is real. It should not be erased.

But internal debate does not erase the historical meaning of Jewish self-determination.

A curriculum would not teach another People's national liberation movement primarily as a matter of whether individual members feel comfortable with it. It would not reduce Indigenous identity to a "range of views" about land. It would not frame Black liberation mainly through disagreement about tactics before first establishing the historical reality of slavery, exclusion, resistance, and rights.

Yet with Jewish identity, the danger is precisely that.

When Zionism is framed mainly as contested belief, students can easily absorb the message that Jewish Peoplehood itself is debatable. They may come away thinking Jewish national identity is optional, suspicious, or merely political — rather than a central feature of Jewish history.

The problem is not that the curriculum acknowledges disagreement.

The problem is that it does not first establish enough historical clarity.

Students need to understand what Zionism is before they are asked to process controversy around it. Zionism did not begin in the nineteenth century. The longing for return to the Land of Israel runs through the Torah, the Hebrew Bible, the Talmud, daily Jewish prayer, the Passover seder, and the liturgy of every major Jewish holiday for more than two thousand years. Jews have faced toward Jerusalem when they pray, mourned its destruction at every wedding, and repeated the words "Next year in Jerusalem" across centuries of exile. Modern political Zionism gave organized form to a longing which was already ancient. It is the political expression of a Peoplehood, a covenant, and a continuous bond to a Homeland which long predates any modern government.

That can be taught factually without requiring students to adopt any political position on contemporary Israeli policy.

Accuracy is not advocacy.

Selection Sends a Signal

Curriculum is not only what is stated. It is also what is selected, centered, softened, or omitted.

The Jewish volume includes significant figures such as Emma Lazarus and Julius Rosenwald. Both are worthy of study. Both contributed meaningfully to American and Jewish life.

But selection creates inference.

When a curriculum highlights a figure's distance from Zionism or presents Jewish national aspirations as uncommon, complicated, or peripheral, while leaving out central American Zionist figures such as Justice Louis Brandeis from the main structure students are likely to see, it sends a message.

Students learn not only from what is taught, but from what the curriculum treats as central.

If the most visible examples soften, qualify, or avoid Jewish national identity, students may reasonably conclude that Jewish virtue lies in contribution, assimilation, philanthropy, humor, service, and cultural success — but not continuity, sovereignty, or self-definition. The message becomes:

Be Jewish, but not too Jewish.

Be historical, but not national.

Be cultural, but not collective.

Be a contributor, but not a People.

That is not how any group's identity should be taught. And it is not new.

For more than two thousand years, Jews have been told by surrounding societies which parts of their identity were acceptable and which parts were not. Be religious, but not too tribal. Be a citizen, but not a Nation. Be loyal to the empire, the church, the state, the revolution — but not to your own People. Assimilate, but do not insist on continuity. Contribute, but do not claim Peoplehood. Survive, but do not Return.

Every era has had its preferred version of the acceptable Jew. And every era has discovered, eventually, that the version which it preferred was still not acceptable enough.

This is the oldest pattern in the history of antisemitism: the demand that Jews shrink themselves to fit the categories of the surrounding society, followed by the discovery that no shrinking is ever sufficient.

A curriculum which quietly asks Jewish students to be cultural but not collective, historical but not National, individual but not a People, is repeating that pattern in the gentlest possible voice.

No community should have to be made smaller in order to be made acceptable.

The Double Standard in Civil Rights Framing

The most consequential issue is not one phrase, one omission, or one biography. It is the asymmetry.

The *Hidden Voices* series does not frame every identity the same way. Some communities are presented through present-day civil rights urgency, policy concerns, hate crime data, government response, activism, and civic engagement.

That approach can be appropriate. Students should understand how discrimination affects real people in the present. They should learn how communities organize, advocate, and seek protection under law.

But Jewish identity deserves the same seriousness.

If one group's story is framed as a living civil rights issue while another's is framed mainly as heritage, memory, and contribution, students learn a hierarchy of urgency.

One group gets policy.

One group gets data.

One group gets civic action.

One group gets protection language.

The other gets empathy, memory, and caution.

That is not parity.

This does not mean that other communities deserve less. They do not. Every group facing prejudice deserves accurate, serious, protective curriculum.

The point is the opposite: Jewish students deserve the same seriousness.

If a school system can name Islamophobia in present tense civic terms, it can name antisemitism in present tense civic terms. If students can learn how anti-Muslim bias affects policy and public life, they can also learn how antisemitism mutates across time: from religious hatred, to racial conspiracy, to economic scapegoating, to Holocaust denial, to anti-Zionist demonization which denies Jews the same right to self-determination granted to other Peoples.

That is not special pleading.

It is equal treatment.

Why This Harms Students

The damage is not abstract. It reaches Jewish and non-Jewish students through the same omissions, but in different ways.

For Jewish students, the damage is personal.

A curriculum which treats Jewish identity as culture without clearly teaching Peoplehood tells Jewish students that their belonging is conditional. They may talk about food, holidays, immigration, humor, and prejudice in the past. But when the conversation reaches Homeland, Zionism, sovereignty, or the modern forms of antisemitism which target Jewish collective identity, the curriculum becomes cautious.

That caution teaches a lesson.

It tells Jewish students that the safest version of Jewishness is the version which does not make anyone uncomfortable. They should not have to shrink their identity into the categories adults find easiest to manage. They should not have to choose between being accepted and being understood.

This is also the same lesson which Jewish students have been taught, in different words, in nearly every society where Jews have lived. Be quieter. Be smaller. Be less visibly tied to your own People. Belong on the terms which the surrounding culture finds comfortable. Jewish history demonstrates, with painful consistency, where that lesson leads when it goes unchallenged. A school system committed to inclusion should not be teaching it again, even gently.

For non-Jewish students, the damage is different but no less serious.

Non-Jewish students need accurate Jewish history in order to understand the world which they are inheriting. They need to know why antisemitism is not just “hate” in a generic sense — why it has appeared in religious, racial, political, economic, nationalist, and anti-Zionist forms, and why conspiracy theories so often attach themselves to Jews. They need to understand why Jewish identity cannot be reduced to synagogue life, Holocaust memory, or American immigrant success. They need to understand why attacks on Jewish self-determination can become attacks on Jewish identity itself.

Without that knowledge, students are left vulnerable to slogans.

They may learn the language of justice without the discipline of history. They may mistake demonization for activism. They may believe that they are opposing oppression while unknowingly repeating old patterns of scapegoating.

That is how antisemitism survives in educated societies.

Not only through ignorance, but through miseducation.

And this matters to every student, not only Jewish ones, because antisemitism has never been only about the Jews. It has always been the earliest visible signal that a society is losing the capacity to tell the truth — about history, about identity, about who belongs and on what terms. Societies which begin by editing the Jews rarely stop with the Jews. The patterns of denial, distortion, scapegoating, and selective erasure which target Jewish identity have, in every historical instance, eventually been turned on others. That is why Jewish history is not a niche subject. It is a diagnostic instrument. Teaching it accurately is not a favor to Jewish students. It is a protection for every student.

Why This Harms Teachers

Teachers are placed in an impossible position.

Most educators want to do the right thing. They want to teach fairly. They want to protect students. They want to avoid political fights. They want clear guidance.

But when a curriculum avoids the hard parts of Jewish history, teachers are left to improvise.

Some will avoid the topic entirely. Some will rely on unvetted online resources. Some will reduce antisemitism to the Holocaust. Some will treat Zionism as a modern political controversy instead of first teaching it as a historical movement of Jewish self-determination. Some will confuse activism for analysis. Some will fear that accurate teaching about Jewish Peoplehood is “too political.”

That vacuum is dangerous in any subject. It is especially dangerous here.

Antisemitism is the oldest organized form of hatred in recorded history. It is also among the most studied. Its patterns are known. Its disguises are documented. Its progression has been written about in every century in which it has appeared. Unlike many forms of prejudice, antisemitism is preventable in the specific sense that we know how it works, how it conceals itself, and how it accelerates when institutions fail to name it clearly.

That makes the vacuum left by an unclear curriculum more than a pedagogical gap. It is a failure to use knowledge which already exists.

When schools fail to teach clearly, the internet teaches instead. So do activist organizations with their own agendas. So do social-media platforms whose algorithms reward outrage over accuracy. So do peer networks shaped by slogans rather than sources. The vacuum does not stay empty. It is filled, every time, by whatever is loudest and most available.

And what is loudest and most available, in this moment, is precisely the rhetoric which antisemitism has historically used to disguise itself: the language of justice borrowed to mask exclusion, the language of liberation borrowed to mask demonization, the language of inclusion borrowed to mask the editing of Jewish identity.

Teachers cannot be expected to recognize and resist all of that on their own. A curriculum should not require them to.

The Real Failure: No Accountability Architecture

The problem with *Hidden Voices* is not only content. It is governance.

Who decided which Jewish figures mattered? Who reviewed the definitions?

Who checked the glossary?

Who compared the Jewish volume to other identity-based volumes for parity?

Who ensured that Jewish Peoplehood was not reduced to culture?

Who evaluated whether the curriculum met civil rights obligations?

Who is responsible for correcting it now?

These questions matter because public school curriculum is not private opinion. It carries institutional authority. When NYCPS brands, distributes, and promotes a curriculum, it gives that curriculum legitimacy.

Families deserve to know what standards were used. Educators deserve clear guidance. Students deserve accuracy. Communities deserve a transparent process for correction when something goes wrong.

A school system cannot simply say that it consulted experts and then ask the Public to trust the result. Consultation is not accountability. Acknowledgment is not accuracy. Representation is not truth.

If a curriculum claims to uncover hidden voices, the public has a right to ask whose voices were softened, edited, or left out again.

These are not hypothetical questions. They have been raised — through proper channels, in writing, to the institutions positioned as partners in this work. What happens when they are raised is the subject of the next piece in this series.

The Larger Lesson

The deeper issue is not only what NYCPS taught about Jews.

It is what this reveals about modern education.

A curriculum can use the language of equity while practicing selective truth. It can celebrate diversity while flattening identity. It can include a group while removing the parts of that group which make adults uncomfortable.

That is why this matters beyond the Jewish community.

If inclusion means that a People can be acknowledged only after their history is edited into acceptable pieces, then inclusion has become performance.

If equity means that some groups receive full historical and civic framing while others receive caution and abstraction, then a curriculum designed to redistribute voice has instead reproduced the very hierarchy of power which it was created to dismantle.

If schools cannot tell the truth about Jewish identity because it is politically inconvenient, then they are not preparing students to think critically. They are training them to avoid reality.

Education must do better.

The Jewish story is not a footnote, a food festival, a prejudice unit, or a collection of admirable individuals. It is the story of an ancient People who carried memory across exile, rebuilt life after catastrophe, contributed profoundly to every society which they entered, and maintained a continuous bond to their ancestral Homeland despite centuries of persecution.

That story does not need to be politicized. It needs to be told.

Because a school system which cannot protect truth cannot protect students.

And inclusion which erases the identity of the included is not inclusion at all.

Source Notes

The curriculum analyzed in this essay is *Hidden Voices: Jewish Americans in United States History, Volume 1*, published by New York City Public Schools. The full *Hidden Voices* collection, including other identity-based volumes referenced in the parity analysis, is available through the NYCPS Hidden Voices initiative page and the WeTeachNYC platform.

The Balfour Declaration of 1917 and the League of Nations Mandate for Palestine of 1922 are available in their original texts through the Avalon Project at Yale Law School (avalon.law.yale.edu), which provides free public access to primary documents in law, history, and diplomacy.

The references to "Next year in Jerusalem," the directional orientation of Jewish prayer toward Jerusalem, the breaking of the glass at Jewish weddings in memory of the destruction of the Temple, and the recurring liturgical themes of exile and return are standard elements of Jewish practice documented in any traditional siddur (prayer book) and Haggadah. For a contemporary scholarly treatment of Jewish Peoplehood, Covenant, and the Centrality of the Land of Israel in Jewish thought, see Rabbi Lord Jonathan Sacks, *Covenant and Conversation* (Maggid Books, multi-volume series).

On the structural history of antisemitism, its mutating forms across religious, racial, political, economic, and anti-Zionist registers, and the contemporary patterns referenced in this essay, see Deborah E. Lipstadt, *Antisemitism: Here and Now* (Schocken Books, 2019). For the longer historical arc tracing antisemitism from antiquity through the modern period, see Robert S. Wistrich, *A Lethal Obsession: Anti-Semitism from Antiquity to the Global Jihad* (Random House, 2010).

On the federal civil-rights framework referenced in the parity analysis, see the U.S. Department of Education Office for Civil Rights guidance on shared ancestry and ethnic characteristics under Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964; the U.S. National Strategy to Counter Antisemitism, released by the White House in May 2023; and the U.S. National Strategy to Counter Islamophobia and Anti-Arab Hate.

This essay is the first in a series examining curriculum, accountability, and civil rights infrastructure in American public education. Subsequent pieces will examine the institutional responses — and non-responses — to the concerns documented here, supported by primary correspondence and the formal evidence-based audit submitted to the curriculum's development team.